from Jaffna on a ship headed to the Maldives. A month later, the R&AW team hired several safe houses in Cambodia to provide them with security. In subsequent months, all the assets were strategically relocated to European countries.'

The need to get the Sri Lankan informers out of the country had been vital, said Avinash. At Kilinochchi in the northern province of Sri Lanka, he revealed, a compound that housed some R&AW informers had had just one survivor that month—a white cat.

The Price of Loyalty

Lasantha Wickrematunge, the fearless editor of the Sri Lankan newspaper The Sunday Leader, was shot dead on 8 January 2009 at around 10.15 a.m. The murder on Attidiya Road, Ratmalana, in Colombo south, executed by two gunmen in broad daylight, panicked the R&AW. Lasantha was not only an excellent journalist, he was also a loyal friend of the Indian spy agency. Javed Faridi, a R&AW officer who had befriended Lasantha even before the civil war had started, was dumbstruck. Faridi said Lasantha had been threatened by government-backed groups for several months and that he had had several rounds of meetings with the newspaperman to discuss who might want to harm him. 'Lasantha suspected Mahinda Rajapaksa and his younger brother Gotabaya Rajapaksa because his newspaper was not only critical of the government, but they were also exposing massive corruption in the defence ministry,' said Faridi.

After Mahinda Rajapaksa's electoral victory in 2005, Gotabaya Rajapaksa had been made secretary of the Sri Lankan defence ministry. A month before he was killed, Lasantha had told Faridi that he was working to unearth a defence scam involving